JUST MAKE NOISE

HOW TO BE AN INDEPENDENT ARTIST IN2026 AND BEYOND

modernnostalgia.club

Chapter 1: The Death of the Old Music Industry

The old way of making it in music is gone. The idea of being “discovered” by some cigar-smoking A&R who takes you from the neighborhood open mic to a Grammy stage is a fairy tale now.

Definition Box: A&R

The talent scouts at a label who look for artists.

Example: The A&R person goes to a show to find the next singer to sign.Labels do not develop talent anymore. They wait until you have already gone viral, built a fanbase, and proven you can sell, then they swoop in to take their cut.

If you are still chasing a label deal as your main plan, you are asking for permission instead of building power. The problem with permission is that the people giving it do not care about you. They care about what they can extract.

Case Study: Fetty Wap vs Chance the Rapper

- Fetty Wap had the biggest song in the country with “Trap Queen.” He signed to 300 Entertainment, got one great year, then fizzled. The label moved on. Fetty did not control his masters, he did not build direct fan infrastructure, and when the hype died, so did the machine.

Definition Box: Masters

The finished recordings of the songs. Whoever owns the masters owns the finished cake.

Example: If a label owns your masters, they own the final recordings.

Definition Box: Direct-to-Fan (D2F)

Selling straight to your supporters without a middle person.

Example: You sell a song bundle to fans from your site.

- Chance the Rapper turned down labels and gave *Coloring Book* away for free. He built his brand on live shows, merch, and direct-to-fan connections. When the Grammys changed rules to allow streaming-only albums, he walked in and took three trophies without signing his soul away.

  Definition Box: Leverage

  Power to make better deals because you bring value.

  Example: If 500 fans buy your bundle, you have leverage to say no to a weak deal.

This is not about talent. It is about leverage. Fetty was talented. Chance was talented. The difference was who owned the house when the storm came.

The truth: the industry never cared about you. It cared about product. Once you stop selling, the factory moves on to the next.

Chapter 2: Streams Are Not a Business Model

Streamingplatforms havetrickedartistsinto believing streams equal stability. They don't. Streams are the new lottery tickets; exciting if you hit, useless if you don't. And the math proves it.

Definition Box: Streaming payout

The tiny money you get per play on a platform like Spotify.

Example: If a stream pays about $0.003, one thousand streams is about three dollars.

The Streaming Math

Spotify pays roughly $0.003 per stream. Let's map that out:

Chart 1: Spotify Payouts

- 1,000 streams = $3 ($1.50 per side, but I'll get there later)
- 10,000 streams = $30
- 100,000 streams = $300
- 1,000,000 streams = $3,000
- 10,000,000 streams = $30,000

Ten million streams sounds insane, but that's a year's salary in most cities. And ten million is not realistic for 99% of artists.

Meanwhile, Direct-to-Fan sales crush that math:

Chart 2: Direct-to-Fan Payouts

- 50 fans spending $20 = $1,000
- 200 fans spending $20 = $4,000
- 1,000 fans spending $20 = $20,000

You don't need millions of strangers. You need hundreds of believers.

Case Study: LaRussell vs Playlist Stars

LaRussell built his empire out of his backyard. He runs live shows on his own turf, lets fans “pay what you want,” and sometimes even splits profits with them. His community is so loyal they treat him like family. He can make $2,000 on a weekend with 200 people showing up.

Compare that to artists with “playlist hits.” They might pull in 5 million Spotify streams, which looks impressive on Instagram. But do the math: 5 million x $0.003 = $15,000 before distributor cuts.

Definition Box: Distributor

A helper company that puts your music on Spotify, Apple, and other platforms.

Example: DistroKid or TuneCore uploads your track so fans can stream it. That’s a whole year’s income for a viral moment, with no guarantee it repeats. Most of those fans don’t even know their name, they just heard the song in a lo-fi playlist once.

Case Study: Russ and Consistency

Russ didn’t just post one viral track and hope. He uploaded one song a week for years. At first, he got a few hundred plays. Then a few thousand. Eventually, millions. The catalog snowballed. By the time labels came knocking, he owned everything. Streams made him money, but only because he had hundreds of songs stacked like real estate.

The Hidden Costs of Streams

There’s also the money you *spend* trying to chase streams:

- Playlist pitching campaigns (legit and scammy).
- Boosted IG ads with no funnel.
- Paying “influencers” to dance to your track.

Definition Box: Boosted post

An ad you pay for that shows your social post to more people.

Example: You spend $20 to make your reel reach strangers.

Most artists drop $500 to $1,000 promoting a single and then celebrate when it gets 20,000 plays. That’s $60 in payout. You just paid more to promote your song than you’ll ever earn back. Streams are good for exposure. They are *not* a business model.

The Direct-to-Fan Alternative

Direct-to-fan sales flip the model: instead of begging a platform for fractions of pennies, you give value to fans directly. EVEN, Bandcamp, Gumroad, Shopify: these tools let you sell Access Points, bundles, loops, merch, even equity shares.

You don't need to gamble on algorithms. You build your own market.

Definition Box: Access Point

A digital bundle fans can buy. It might include a song, extras, or even a small share.

Example: A $20 pack with the single, stems, and a behind-the-scenes video.

Mini Example: EVEN Access Points

- Sell a $5 eBook to 200 fans = $1,000
- Sell a $50 "song equity share" to 20 fans = $1,000
- Bundle: 100 fans buy both = $5,500

That'sreal money with real ownership, no middleman.

Checklist: How to Earn Your First $1,000 Without Spotify

Consistency: if you're not going to drop every week, socials go a long way. That being said, it's not GOSPEL, not the way people make it seem. Simply put, the more they see you, the more they r

Identify 50 fans whocare : friends, followers, supporters. You know 50 people that support you.

Create a $20 product: an Access Point, a merch bundle, or equity share.

Sell directly: EVEN, Bandcamp, or email list.

Stack wins: repeat untilyou hit $1,000. Then scale.

Chapter 3: Labels Are Just Banks (Bad Ones)

Recordlabels liketo paintthemselves as dream-makers. They'll tell you they "believe in you," that they're "investing in your future," that they'll "take you to the next level." Strip away the fancy language and the truth is simple: a record deal is just a loan. And not even a fair one.

Definition Box: Advance

Money a label gives you now that you must pay back later from your music income.

Example: You get 50,000 dollars now, but you do not get royalties until the label gets paid back.

How Advances Really Work

When a label gives you an advance (say $50,000), that money is not free. It's not a gift. It's a loan you have to pay back through your own royalties. And until it's recouped (when a record label or publisher recovers its expenses, such as recording and marketing costs), you don't see a dime.

Here's what most artists don't realize:

- The label decides how the money is spent. That "$50,000 advance" might already include recording, marketing, and tour support. You don't get a check to pocket.
- The label usually takes 80 percent or more of your revenue. Even after recouping, you're left with scraps.
- The label owns your masters. That means they control your music forever, even after you've paid off the loan.

Case Study: Taylor Swift vs Her Masters

Taylor Swift is one of the biggest artists in the world. But even she lost control of her early albums when Big Machine sold her catalog to Scooter Braun's group. Taylor had to re-record her entire discography just to own her work again. If the most powerful pop star alive can get trapped, what happens to a kid with no leverage?

Case Study: TLC's Bankruptcy

TLC sold millions of records in the 90s. "Waterfalls," "No Scrubs," global hits. And yet, they filed for bankruptcy at the height of their success. Why? Their label deal was structured so badly that despite selling platinum, they couldn't pay bills. The label ate first, always.

Case Study: Prince and “Slave”

Prince fought Warner Bros. so hard he started writing the word “SLAVE” on his face in protest. He wanted control of his masters, they refused, and he went to war. Prince was right. Masters are power. Without them, you’re a worker in someone else’s factory.

Chart: Bank Loan vs Label Advance

	Bank Loan	Label Advance
Loan amount	$50,000	$50,000
How you spend it	You decide	Label decides
Payback terms	Fixed payments	All royalties until recouped
Ownership after repayment	You own your house	Label still owns your masters
Interest	5–20%	Infinite, because they keep control forever

When you line it up this way, a label deal looks less like a dream and more like a predatory payday loan.

The Trap of 360 Deals

Modern labels have made it worse with “360 deals.” Not only do they take a cut of your music, they take a cut of everything: merch, touring, sponsorships, even acting gigs. They’re basically saying: “We own you.”

The Indie Alternative

Indie doesn’t mean “alone.” It means *independent*. Forming an LLC, setting up your own bank accounts, and using platforms like EVEN and HRMNY lets you build your own machine. You can still borrow money if you need it, but from a real bank or from your fans, not from a label that owns you.

Checklist: Spotting a Bad Deal

Before you sign anything:

Ask who owns the masters - if it's not you, think twice.

Look at recoupment terms - if you don't get paid until "infinity plus one," walk away.

Check if it's a 360 deal - if they want your touring and merch, that's a red flag.

Do the math - compare the advance to what you could make with direct-to-fan.

Remember - if Taylor, TLC, and Prince got burned, so can you.

Chapter 4: The Indie Artist as CEO

Being anartist today is not just about writing songs and posting on TikTok. You're running a small business. Every song you release is an asset. Every fan you convert is a customer. Every catalog you build is equity. If you don't think like a CEO, you'll always be working for someone who does.

Why Structure Matters

Without structure, your music career is just a hobby with receipts. With structure, it becomes a business that banks, sponsors, and fans take seriously. You can't walk into a grant program, pitch a sponsorship, or build credit without looking like a business. And the beauty is, it doesn't take a lot of money to set up.

Step One: Form an LLC

An LLC (Limited Liability Company) separates your personal life from your business. If someone sues your music business, they can't take your personal car or your mom's house. It also opens the door to tax benefits, grants, and business credit.

- Filing cost: usually $50-$300, depending on the state.
- EIN (Employer Identification Number): free from the IRS.
- Operating agreement: you can draft one yourself with free templates.

Mini Case Study: modernnostalgia.club
By forming an LLC, MNC was able to open business bank accounts, apply for trade lines, and start separating personal spending from business spending. That foundation made it possible to move fast when opportunities came up - whether that was pitching sponsorships or writing off studio expenses.

Step Two: Get Your DUNS

A DUNS number is basically a Social Security Number for your business. It tracks your credit history. You need it if you ever want loans, lines of credit, or vendor accounts. The best part: it's free.

Once you have a DUNS, you can start building business credit separate from your personal score. That means you don't have to risk your own name every time you take a chance on your art.

Step Three: Net-30 Accounts and Trade Lines

This is where indie artists usually check out - but this is also where the power is. A net-30 account is a vendor that gives you 30 days to pay for something. You buy $100 worth of supplies, they report your on-time payment to credit bureaus, and your business credit grows.

- Uline, Quill, Grainger: classic starter accounts.
- Nav: helps track your business credit and connects to lenders.
- Even digital platforms like PayPal Working Capital count as trade lines.

Over time, you build a credit history that makes you eligible for bigger lines - credit cards, equipment financing, even loans for tours.

Step Four: Separate Your Money

Open a business checking account. Use it only for business. Every dollar in and out should go through that account. It makes taxes easier, it builds credibility, and it forces you to treat your music like a business, not a side hustle.

Recommended:

- Novo (online bank for small businesses).
- QuickBooks Checking (syncs with accounting).
- PayPal Business (easy for fans and clients).

Step Five: Think Like a CEO

Everydollar should be treated like capital. Ask:

- Does this expense grow the business?
- Can I write this off?
- Will this increase long-term equity?

Your songs are assets. Your catalog is your portfolio. Your LLC is your company. You are not just an artist, you are the CEO of your own record label, publisher, and merch company rolled into one.

Checklist: Building Your Foundation This Month

File your LLC.

Get your EIN.

Apply for a DUNS.

Open a business checking account.

Apply for at least one net-30 account.

Connect to Nav and track your credit.

Run all music expenses through your business.

Chapter 5: Direct-to-Fan is the Root

Ifyoutake nothing else from thisbook, takethis:direct-to-fan isnotan option,it's the foundation. Without it, you're building on sand. With it, you're building on bedrock.

Why Direct-to-Fan Matters

When you sell through streaming platforms or labels, you're just a supplier. They own the customer relationship. Spotify has the emails, YouTube has the subscriber list, Instagram has the followers. You don't. If one of those platforms shuts down your account, you lose everything.

Direct-to-fan flips that. You own the connection. You know who your fans are, how to reach them, and how to offer them things that create real value both for them and for you.

Direct-to-fan is the difference between chasing clout and building wealth.

The EVEN Model: Access Points

EVEN is one of the most powerful tools for this shift. Instead of dropping music on Spotify and hoping, you build **Access Points**, digital bundles that fans can buy directly.

An Access Point might include:

- The song itself.
- Stems or loops.
- Behind-the-scenes content.
- Merch discounts.
- Revenue shares (fans owning a percentage of future earnings).

The $20 Fan Principle

There'safamous idea called the "1,000 true fans" theory. The math is simple:

- If1,000 people spend $100 per year with you, that's $100,000.
- If1,000 people spend $20, that's $20,000.

You don'tneed millions of streams. You need a few hundred dedicated fans who buy in directly.
Chart: Streams vs Direct Fans

- 1,000,000 streams = $3,000
- 150 fans spending $20 = $3,000

Whichfeels more realistic?

Examples of Direct-to-Fan Success

- **LaRussell**: runs backyard shows, lets fans pay what they want, splits profits. His fans feel like co-owners of his journey.
- **LaRussell's motto**: "How could I lose, if I'm already who the people choose?" That's direct-to-fan in one line.

The Indie Failure: Cul-de-Saccing

Here's the opposite. Too many artists commit what I call **cul-de-saccing**. That's when you put a link in your bio that goes nowhere. No funnel, no call-to-action, no next step. Fans hit the dead end and bounce.

Example cul-de-sac moves:

- Linktree that just points to Spotify.
- IG bio link that goes to YouTube, with no subscribe button.
- Merch page with no checkout.

Direct-to-Fan Tools

- **EVEN**: for Access Points and equity shares.
- **Bandcamp**: classic for digital albums and merch.
- **Shopify**: powerful if you want to build a full store.
- **Gumroad**: simple way to sell digital bundles.
- **Email & SMS lists**: the most valuable of all since they can't be taken away.

Checklist: Building Your Direct-to-Fan Engine

Audit your current link in bio: is it a cul-de-sac? Fix it.

Create at least one product at $20 value (song bundle, merch, or Access Point).

Start building an email or SMS list.

Sell directly to 50 fans. Celebrate, then repeat.

Make every release morelike a transaction than a stream.

Chapter 6: Sync Licensing as the Second Root

Ifdirect-to-fan is the bedrock,sync licensing is theanchor. It's steady,it's scalable, and unlike chasing streams, it doesn't care if you're "hot on TikTok." Sync pays when a song is placed in film, TV, ads, video games, trailers, pretty much anywhere music meets picture.

Why Sync Matters

- **It pays upfront and on the back end.** You get a fee for the placement, and you collect performance royalties when it airs.
- **It doesn't require celebrity status.** Music supervisors don't care if you have a million followers. They care if the song fits the scene.
- **It's evergreen.** A song you made five years ago can land in a movie tomorrow.

The One-Stop Rule

To land syncs, you need your music to be **one-stop**: that means everything is cleared and ready. No messy splits, no uncontactable producers, no lawsuits waiting in the wings. One email, one contract, one green light.

Case Study: **Moon Yecca's "Unwelcome"**

Pre-cleared, one-stop, and sync-friendly. That track could move today because it doesn't need three weeks of chasing down signatures. **Supervisors want instant clearance**.

Case Study: Epidemic vs HRMNY

Epidemic Sound built a business by asking artists to give up PRO rights (meaning they give up royalties forever) in exchange for upfront cash. That works for hobbyists, but it's a trap for career artists. You make pennies now, lose thousands later.

HRMNY flips that script: keep your PRO rights, keep your royalties, and still get placements. Ownership is always better than surrender.

Why Indie Artists Should Prioritize Sync

- **Mailbox money.** When your song is placed, your PRO (ASCAP, BMI, SOCAN, IMRO, etc.) pays you every quarter.
- **Global exposure.** A sync in a Netflix show is worth more than 10 Spotify playlist adds.
- **Catalog monetization.** Old songs or new songs, they're all assets waiting for the right scene.

Failure Case: Artists With Hits but No Syncs

Take Silento's "Watch Me (Whip/Nae Nae)." Viral, massive, everywhere. But sync supervisors couldn't touch it because it was messy: too many writers, too much legal baggage, and no one-stop clearance. That's a perfect example of a song with hype but no longevity.

Meanwhile, indie artists with no viral fame land syncs every month because their songs are clear and usable.

Checklist: Building Sync into Your Strategy

Make every song one-stop. Clear splits in writing before release.

Register with a PRO (ASCAP, BMI, SOCAN, IMRO).

Build metadata: BPM, mood tags, lyrics, clean and instrumental versions.

Upload to a sync library like HRMNY or Disco.

Pitch directly to supervisors. Follow up. Be reliable.

Chapter 8: Marketing That Does Not Waste Money

Marketing is where most indie artists lightmoney onfire.They boost an Instagram post, drop $200 on a playlist plug, or hire some shady “PR team” that sends their song to dead email lists. At the end of it all, they have nothing to show but screenshots and a lighter wallet.

The truth: most marketing advice for indie artists is a scam. If you do not control the funnel, you are throwing cash at strangers who do not care.

Why (Random) Boosted Posts Do Not Work

Instagram will gladly take your money to show your video to 5,000 random people. The problem is that “reach” does not equal fans. Unless your boosted post drives people to a clear action join your email list, buy an Access Point, subscribe, you are paying for vanity.

Mini Example: An artist spends $300 boosting a single promo post. They get 20,000 impressions and 200 likes. That looks good on the surface. But zero fans bought merch, zero joined the list, and zero came to shows. That $300 could have been used to create 15 $20 Access Point sales: $300 in revenue plus 15 real connections

The Funnel Approach

Marketing only works if it moves fans through a funnel:

1. **Attention**: short-form content (TikTok, Reels, Shorts).
2. **Interest**: long-form content (YouTube, live sessions, behind the scenes).
3. **Commitment**: direct-to-fan sale (Access Point, merch, bundle).

The mistake artists make is stopping at step one. They get attention, but they have nowhere to take it.

Case Study: Sound.me vs Empty Ads

Platforms like Sound.me connect artists with micro-influencers and dancers who already create content daily. Paying $50 to $100 to a creator with a loyal audience can get more traction than $500 spent on broad ads. Why? Because the influencer has community trust.

Compare:

- $100 boosted IG post = random strangers scroll past.
- $100 to a micro-influencer in your genre = content that lives forever and drives fans back to your link.

Build Your Own Media Machine

The best marketing is not about buying attention, it is about owning distribution. That means:

- Building an email list.
- Running a SMS list.
- Creating consistent content on platforms you control (YouTube, your site, your store).

Whenyou own the channel, you do not need to beg algorithms.

The Case of Clout vs Conversion

Plenty of artists chase clout: millions of views, viral dances, reposts from big pages. But clout without conversion is useless. You cannot pay rent with views.

On the other side, artists who focus on conversion (even small numbers) win. If you convert 100 fans into $50 sales, that is $5,000. That can fund your next release, pay for a small tour, and buy time to make more art.

Checklist: Stop Wasting Marketing Money

Stop boosting posts without a funnel.

Define your funnel: attention → interest → commitment.

Build an email and SMS list now.

Test micro-influencers, not mass ads.

Measure conversion, not clout.

Reinvest profits into direct-to-fan tools, not vanity.

Chapter 9: Building a Team and Community

Being indie does not meandoing everything alone. It meansyou chooseyourteam instead of a label forcing one on you. You pick the collaborators, the curators, the managers, and the fans who become part of your engine. And when you do it right, community becomes your greatest asset.

Why Community Beats Clout

Clout is a stranger liking your post. Community is 20 people showing up at your show with cash in hand. Clout looks good on social media screenshots. Community keeps the lights on.

Community gives you:

- People to amplify your drops.
- Collaborators to push creativity.
- Curators to plug you into new listeners.
- Asafety net when the algorithms stop feeding you.

Curators Matter

Playlist curators and culture curators are the invisible hand of taste. They connect songs to ears. Metroknome, Knowvibes, RNBeard — people like that are bridges between artists and listeners. If you win over the right curator, you can bypass the whole playlist pitch machine.

Case Study: RNBeard and RnBRadar
RNBeard built trust as a tastemaker. His playlists and reviews gave indie R&B artists credibility before the majors noticed. He wasn't a label, he wasn't a manager, but he influenced who people listened to. That is community power.

Collaborators Multiply Reach

Every time you work with another artist, you tap into their world. Whether its songwriting camps, feature swaps or production trades, all of these spread your reach without you spending money on ads.

Barter is a Superpower

When you don't have money, trade. Your beats for their hooks. Your mixing for their video. Your merch design for their feature. Money is one form of currency, but time, skills, and community are currencies too.

Example: An artist trades a verse for cover art. Both win. No money spent, but both gain an asset they can monetize.

Community vs Industry "Connections"

Plenty of artists brag about "industry connects." They know someone at a label, they shook hands at a showcase, they DM'd a manager once. But industry connects are not community. Those people disappear when you can't offer them leverage.

Community sticks. Community shows up. Build horizontally, not just vertically.

Checklist: Building Your Indie Community

Identify 3 to 5 curators in your genre. Build with them.

Host or join a writing camp or session swap.

Support your peers publicly: repost, co-sign, show up.

Think long-term: who do you want in your 5-year circle?

Chapter 10: Time Management and Productivity

Being indie meansyou wear every hat. Youare the artist,theCEO, the marketer,the bookkeeper, and the roadie. If you don't manage your time, the hats crush you. The artists who survive are not always the most talented; they are the ones who learn how to juggle.

Why Time Management is Non-Negotiable

Without a system:

- Songs don't get finished.
- Releases pile up with no strategy.
- Marketing gets rushed.
- Money gets sloppy.

Talentisthe spark. Systems are the fuel.

Batching Tasks

One of the simplest productivity hacks is batching. Instead of bouncing between tasks all day, you dedicate blocks of time to one type of work.

Examples:

- Monday: content creation day (film reels, edit, schedule).
- Tuesday: studio writing and production.
- Wednesday: admin and emails.
- Thursday: mixing and finishing tracks.
- Friday: live practice, networking, or shows.

By batching, you reduce mental clutter. You know what the day is for, so you can go deep instead of shallow.

The “2-Hour CEO Block”

Every indie artist should spend at least two hours a week purely on the CEO side of their business: money, planning, strategy. That means no headphones, no DAW, no mic. Just you and your business brain.

Mini Case Study: Kevin Smith
When Kevin Smith shot *Clerks*, he was working at a convenience store full time. He wrote and planned during slow shifts, shot at night, and edited whenever he could. He had no money, but he had time discipline. That is why his film launched a career while others stayed ideas on a napkin.

The 80/20 Rule

80 percent of your results come from 20 percent of your effort. The trick is finding which 20 percent matters. For some artists, it is sync pitching. For others, it is selling Access Points. For others, it is building community. Once you know the 20 percent, protect it.

Productivity Tools That Work

- **Google Calendar or Notion**: block your week in advance.
- **Trello orAsana** : track tasks and projects.
- **ClickUp**: one dashboard for music, business, and marketing.
- **Pomodoro timer**: work in 25-minute sprints with breaks.

The toolmatters less than using it consistently.

Case Study: Russ and Volume Systems

Russ did not just write when inspiration struck. He built a system: one song per week, every week. That volume forced him to get better, faster, and more disciplined. Systems create output.

Output creates leverage.

Checklist: Time Discipline for Indie Artists

Batch tasks by day.

Schedule a 2-hour CEO block weekly.

Identify your personal 20 percent.

Pick one productivity tool and stick with it.

Release on a consistentschedule.

Chapter 11: Case Studies of Indie Success

Sometimes the best wayto learn isto watch howothers did it.These casestudies are not fairy tales. They are roadmaps, each showing a different way an artist built independence through direct-to-fan, sync, ownership, or sheer consistency.

Russ: The Volume Play

Russ is the poster child for consistency. He dropped one song per week for years, building a catalog brick by brick. At first, the plays were small. Over time, they snowballed. By the time he broke into the mainstream, he owned everything: his masters, his publishing, his fanbase.

- **Lesson**: Volume systems work. Treat songs like real estate. The more you own, the more value compounds.
- **Takeaway for readers**: Do not wait for perfection. Build a release system and trust the compounding effect.

LaRussell: TheBackyard Mogul

LaRussell turned his backyard into a venue, his community into investors, and his catalog into equity. He lets fans pay what they want at shows, sometimes even splitting profits with them. He sells Access Points that give fans a literal stake in his songs.

- **Lesson**: Direct-to-fan is not just about sales. It is about building culture.
- **Takeaway for readers**: Your community is enough. Start with who you have and build upward.

Jon Bellion: The Hybrid Creative

Jon Bellion built his career by writing for others and himself. He landed syncs, wrote hits for pop stars, and used that money to fund his artistry. He did not separate the songwriter from the performer. He became both.

- **Lesson**: Sync and publishing can bankroll your artistry.
- **Takeaway for readers**: Do not be precious. A song that funds your career, even if sung by someone else, is part of your empire.

Kennedy Ryon: Sync-First Strategy

Kennedy Ryon leaned into sync licensing as her primary income stream. Instead of chasing charts, she built a catalog tailored to TV and film. Her songs travel globally without her needing millions of followers.

- **Lesson**: Sync is a lane, not a side hustle.
- **Takeaway for readers**: Your music career does not have to be public-facing to be profitable.

Checklist: Applying Case Study Lessons

Pick your model: volume (Russ), community (LaRussell), hybrid (Jon Bellion), or sync-first (Kennedy Ryon)

Adapt it to your scale. Do not copy, customize.

Document your process.Your case study might inspire the next artist.

Chapter 12: The Future: Artist as Small Business CEO

The indie artist ofthe futureis notjust a singeror rapper. Theyare a small business CEO.They run a company built on songs, fans, and systems. They treat their art like an asset, their catalog like real estate, and their community like shareholders.

The old dream was “get signed.” The new dream is “get structured.”

What the New CEO Artist Looks Like

- **Owns their masters.** Songs are assets that grow in value.
- **Runs an LLC.** Their business is protected, bankable, and creditworthy.
- **Sells direct-to-fan.** Fans are not passive listeners, they are investors and partners.
- **Leverages sync.** Catalog keeps working even when they are not online.
- **Uses credit andwrite-offs.** Business expenses turn into growth, not debt.
- **Builds horizontally.** They diversify into merch, publishing, events, sponsorships, and beyond.

Brand Partnerships and Sponsorships

The next wave of indie success will come from partnerships. Not begging brands for crumbs, but creating campaigns that make sense. An artist who can say “I sold 500 Access Points directly” is more attractive to a brand than one with 5 million passive streams. Why? Because ownership and data prove you have real influence.

Cross-Media Expansion

Music is the root, but the branches reach everywhere. Indie artists are already writing scripts, designing fashion, hosting podcasts, and running community shows. In the next decade, indie CEOs will not just release albums, they will release entire media ecosystems.

Community Hubs as the New Labels

The label of the future is not Universal. It is a collective. A hub where curators, producers, artists, and fans co-own the experience.LaRussell’s backyard is one example. These hubs replace the label’s infrastructure with community infrastructure.

The Big Truth

The major label system is not coming back. That is not bad news. That is freedom. The indie artist who learns to run their career like a business will outlast the hype cycle, out-earn the one-hit wonders, and outgrow the need for permission.

Thefuture does not belong to the artist waiting in a label's lobby. It belongs to the artist signing theirown checks.

Checklist: Stepping Into the Future

Own your music.

Structure your business.

Build direct-to-fan funnels.

Pitch for sync consistently.

Think horizontally: music, merch, media, community.

Build a hub, not just a profile.

Glossary of Key Terms

Cul-de-saccing
Whenan artist sends fans to a dead-end link, like a Linktree that only points to Spotify or YouTube with no next step. A missed opportunity to guide fans deeper into your ecosystem.

Direct-to-Fan (D2F)
Astrategywhere artists sell directly to their supporters instead of going through middlemen like labels or streaming platforms. Examples include selling Access Points, merch, bundles, and tickets directly.

DUNS Number
Aunique nine-digit identifier for businesses, issued by Dun & Bradstreet. It tracks your business credit history and is required to build trade lines and get loans.

EIN
Employer Identification Number. Issued by the IRS for free, it is like a Social Security number for your business. Needed for taxes, bank accounts, and payroll.

LLC (Limited Liability Company)
A legal structurethat separates your personal life from your business. Protects your personal assets from lawsuits and allows you to open business bank accounts, apply for credit, and write off expenses.

Metadata
Theinformation attached to your songs: BPM, mood tags, lyrics, composer names, PRO details. Supervisors need this for sync placements.

Net-30 Account
Atype ofvendor credit account that gives you 30 days to pay. Paying on time builds business credit. Examples include Uline, Quill, and Grainger.

One-Stop
Whenasong can be licensed with one email and one agreement because everything is cleared and owned. Essential for sync licensing.

PRO (Performing Rights Organization)
Organizationsthat collectperformanceroyalties for artists and songwriters. Examples include ASCAP, BMI (United States), SOCAN (Canada), and IMRO (Ireland).

Sync Licensing
Theprocess oflicensing music for use in visual media like film, TV, video games, ads, and trailers. Sync pays upfront fees and back-end royalties.

Resource Directory

Direct-to-Fan Platforms

- EVEN: Access Points for direct-to-fan sales and fan equity. https://even.biz
- Bandcamp: Classic indie marketplace for digital albums and merch. https://bandcamp.com
- Gumroad: Easy way to sell digital bundles and files. https://gumroad.com
- Shopify: Full e-commerce store builder for merch and digital goods. https://shopify.com

Sync Licensing Tools

- HRMNY.pro: Sync licensing service with pre-cleared indie music. https://hrmny.pro
- Disco.ac: Industry-standard catalog sharing and pitching tool. https://disco.ac
- Songtradr: Licensing marketplace for indie artists. https://songtradr.com

Business Setup

- IRS: Apply for your free EIN. https://irs.gov
- Dun & Bradstreet: Get your DUNS number. https://dnb.com
- Quill: Office supply vendor with net-30 accounts. https://quill.com
- Grainger: Equipment supplier with net-30 accounts. https://grainger.com

Business Banking & Finance

- Novo: Business checking for small businesses. https://novo.co
- QuickBooks: Accounting and checking solutions. https://quickbooks.intuit.com
- PayPal Business: Global payments for small businesses. https://paypal.com/business
- Nav: Business credit tracking and financing. https://nav.com

Productivity & Organization

- Google Calendar: Free scheduling and time blocking. https://calendar.google.com
- Trello: Visual project management. https://trello.com
- Asana: Team-based project and task management. https://asana.com
- ClickUp: All-in-one productivity platform. https://clickup.com

Curators & Community Examples

- Knowvibes: Curator with a focus on indie culture.
- RNBeard: Tastemaker behind RnBRadar.
- modernnostalgia.club: Ecosystem hub for indie artists. https://modernnostalgia.club

---

Quiz: Test Your Indie Artist Knowledge

1. What is the difference between a stream and a sale?

- Astream pays a fraction of a cent. A sale builds direct revenue and ownership.

2. What is cul-de-saccing, and why is it a mistake?

- Itis sending fans to a dead-end link. It wastes attention instead of converting it.

3. Why is a song being one-stop important for sync?

- Supervisors need instant clearance. If your track has messy splits, it won't get placed.

4. Name three things you can write off as a music business expense.

- Studio time, travel for shows, software subscriptions.

5. What are the two roots of a sustainable indie career according to this book?

- Direct-to-Fan and Sync Licensing.

Music words

Songmaster: The finalrecording of the song. Think of it like the finished cake. Whoever owns the master owns the cake.

Publishing: The song as writing on paper. The lyrics and melody. Think of it like the recipe for the cake.

Writer share: The part of money that goes to the people who wrote the song.

Publisher share: The part of money that goes to the company or person who handles the song writing business.

Stems: Separate tracks from a song, like just the drums or just the vocals. Lego pieces of the song.

Instrumental: The song without singing. Music only.

Clean version: A version with no bad words.

BPM: Beats per minute. How fast a song is. Like counting steps while you run.

Metadata: Helpful tags for a song. Who made it, how fast it is, what mood it fits. Like a name tag and notes on a school project.
ISRC: An ID number for each recording. A license plate for your song master.

UPC: An ID number for a release or album. A barcode for the whole box of songs.

Split sheet: A paper that says who owns what percent of the song. Like dividing a pizza and writing it down.
One-stop: All the people who own the song say yes in one place. One call and you are done.

Sync: When a song is used with video, like in a show, movie, ad, or game.

Sync fee: Money paid to use your song in that video.

Performance royalty: Money paid when your song gets played on TV, radio, or in public.

Mechanical royalty: Money paid when your song is copied or streamed.

Neighboring rights: Money for the people who performed on the recording when it is played in some places. Like a tip jar for the band.
PRO: Performing Rights Organization. A club that collects your performance money and pays you. Examples are ASCAP, BMI, SOCAN, IMRO.
Distributor: The helper that puts your music on Spotify and other platforms.

Playlist: A list of songs picked by a person or a computer.

A and R: Artist and Repertoire. The talent scouts at a label who look for artists.

Money and business words

LLC: Limited Liability Company. A simple company you own. It keeps your personal stuff safe if the business has a problem.

EIN: A number from the IRS for your business. Like a Social Security number for your company.

DUNS number: A number for your business credit report. Like a report card for how your business pays bills.
Business credit: A score for your company that shows if you pay on time. **Net 30:** A deal where you buy now and have 30 days to pay the bill. **Trade line:** An account that reports your on time payments, which helps your business credit. **Advance:** Money a label gives you now that you must pay back later from your music money.

Recoup: When the label gets its money back before you get paid.

360 deal: A deal where the label takes a cut of almost everything. Music, shows, merch, and more.

Royalty: Moneypaidto you when your music is used.

Revenue: Allthemoney you bring in before expenses.

Expense: Moneyyouspend to run the business.

Profit: Moneyleftafterexpenses are paid.

Cash flow: Moneycoming in and going out each month. Like water in a sink.

Write off : Anexpense you are allowed to subtract when doing taxes.

Invoice: Abillyousend when someone owes you money.

Accounts receivable: Money people still owe you.

Accounts payable: Money you still owe to others.

Line of credit: A pot of money from a bank you can use, then pay back, then use again.

Interest: Extra money you pay when you borrow.

Capital: Money you use to grow the business.

Asset: Something valuable your business owns. Songs are assets.

Equity: Ownership. Your slice of the pie.

Direct to fan words

Direct to fan: Selling straight to your supporters. No middle person.

Access Point: A bundle fans can buy. It can include the song, extras, and sometimes a small share.

Equity share for fans: Fans get a tiny piece of future money from a song. Like owning one Lego from your castle.

Email list: A list of fan emails so you can talk to them any time.

SMS list: A list of fan phone numbers to text them updates and offers.

Merch: Stuff you sell like shirts and hats.

Bundle: A package of things sold together at one price.

Cul-de-saccing: Putting a link that leads nowhere useful. A dead end for fans.

Checkout: The page where a fan pays you.

QR code: A square picture people scan with a phone to open a link.

Marketing and growth words

Funnel: The pathfrom noticing you,tolikingyou,tobuyingfromyou. Like slides at a playground that lead to the pool.

Conversion: When a person does what you wanted, like buying or joining your list.

Conversion rate: Out of 100 people who saw it, how many did the thing.

Clout: Internet attention that looks cool but may not bring money.

ROI: Return on investment. If you spend 10 dollars on ads and make 30 dollars, your ROI is good.

Micro-influencer: A creator with a smaller but loyal audience.

Algorithm: The computer system that decides what posts people see.

Organic reach: People who see your stuff without paying for ads.

Boosted post: An ad made from a social post you paid to show to more people.

CTA: Call to action. The clear next step you tell fans to take, like click here or join now.

KPI: Key number you track to see if things are working, like sales per week.

Sync and film words

Music supervisor: Theperson who picks songsfor shows, movies, ads, and games.

Master use license: Permission to use the recording in a show or ad.

Sync license: Permission to match the song writing with picture.

Clearance: Gettingall owners to say yes so the song can be used.

Cue sheet: Aformthat lists which songs got used in a show so the right people get paid.

Team and roles words

Manager: Helpsrunthe artist’sbusinessdaytoday.

Agent: Booksliveshows and tours.

Publicist: Getspress and media to talk about you.

Producer: Helpsmake the song sound great, like the coach of the recording.

Mixing engineer: Balances all the sounds so the song is clear.

Mastering engineer: Finishes the sound so it works everywhere.

Curator: Atastemaker who picks songs for people to hear.

Label: A company that helps release and market music. Sometimes it owns the masters.

Tech and tools words

DAW: DigitalAudio Workstation. The music program you record in, like Pro Tools or Ableton.

Catalog: Allthe songs you have released or control. Your music library.

Dashboard: Ascreen that shows your important numbers in one place.

CRM: Acontact list tool for fans and buyers so you can keep in touch.

E-commerce: Selling things online.

CMS: Awebsite tool to manage pages and posts.

SKU: Acodeyou give each merch item so you can track it.

Fulfillment: Packing and shipping orders to fans.